



levels. We wanted to make a difference in the careers of certain players and provide that missing opportunity," he explained.

Satisfied with how the third edition unfolded, the 31-year-old suggested a desire to see the tournament get bigger in the future.

"I think we have improved on several aspects from the previous year. And similarly, we want to keep improving in every area — the field and playing hall, the spectator, media and broadcast experiences, every small and major thing. We want to keep making it better," he said.

One obvious way to scale up is to attract even bigger names, suggests leading Indian coach RB Ramesh.

"This tournament is already very good from the Indian perspective. Maybe the next step is to have mostly foreign players — like Magnus, Hikaru [Nakamura]. Out of ten, seven would be such players, and the rest, Indians. Even this time, if [R] Praggnanandhaa,

[D] Gukesh, Arvind [Chidambaram] had played, it would have been amazing," said Ramesh.

Srinath confirmed that this is something they are considering for the next edition, while asserting that the present balance will be preserved.

"We will try to schedule it much earlier next year so that we get better player availability. [But] There is no intention to reduce the number of Indian players. We usually have four Indians and six foreigners, and we are definitely not reducing it to fewer than four. But we will try to have a stronger field," added Srinath.

In tune with its expansion plans, the Chennai Grand Masters 2025 drew a riveting response from local fans. Across the nine-day event, the commentary and viewing area was packed, with young, aspiring players eagerly engaging with commentators and participants, discussing moves and complex positions.

After each round, the

Rock solid: The 20-year-old Keymer won the tournament in dominant fashion. B. VELANKANNIRAJ

Grandmasters were greeted with long serpentine queues of supporters waiting for autographs and photos.

As expected, Keymer was the star attraction in the fan zone. His allure only grew as the tournament progressed, as he enthralled everyone with a quality of chess that whispered world champion potential.

Back in 2023, Gukesh banked heavily on a win here at the inaugural edition of the Chennai Grand Masters to qualify for the Candidates. He would then go on to win the World Championship — with Keymer among his seconds.

Now, by winning the 2025 title at the same venue where Carlsen first assumed the throne, Keymer has lined up the pieces for a parallel that may not be too hard to trace.